

Solution Guide

Reference answers scored on three dimensions

This is your model-answer companion. For every pain point you will find the fitting Cisco solution, how a strong Solution Engineer explains it, and the outcome it delivers, mapped to the three scoring dimensions so you can award marks consistently.

The customer. Cedarline Health Group is a regional healthcare payer-provider with roughly 8,000 employees across four hospitals and thirty-one clinics, plus a claims-processing business that handles the money. Growth by acquisition (including a second data centre absorbed as-is) and a mid-flight, disorderly move to public cloud have left a fragmented security posture. After a security incident in March, the board asked what would have stopped it, and leadership still cannot answer. Budget and executive attention are approved but explicitly temporary, and the security team is small.

Three dimensions, 25 points per pain point

Score every pain point on the three dimensions below. They sum to 25, so four pain points make 100 per case study and four case studies make 400 in total.

 Problem Identifier / 5 Correctly identified the customer's pain point and the requirements behind it.	 Solution Designer / 10 Recommended the right Cisco solution, architecture, and approach.	 Value Communicator / 10 Clearly explained how the solution works and the customer outcomes it enables.
--	---	---

How to award the points

 Problem Identifier score 0 to 5	
5	Precisely identifies the pain point and the requirements or constraints behind it.
3 to 4	Identifies the pain point but misses some requirements or nuance.
1 to 2	Vague or partial understanding of the concern.
0	Misreads the concern, or leaves it blank.

 Solution Designer score 0 to 10	
8 to 10	Recommends the right Cisco solution and an architecture or approach that fits Cedarline and the HMF design.
5 to 7	Right solution, but light on the architecture or approach.
2 to 4	Partly right, or a product named with no approach.
0 to 1	Wrong solution, or left blank.

 Value Communicator score 0 to 10	
8 to 10	Clearly explains how the solution works and the concrete Cedarline outcomes it enables.
5 to 7	Explains how it works but is thin on outcomes, or states outcomes without the how.
2 to 4	Vague or generic.

0 to
1

No explanation, or left blank.

1

CASE STUDY 1 · REFERENCE

AI Security

The conversation. Cedarline is standing up AI across regulated workflows and public cloud faster than security can see it. Help them prove compliance, vet what they adopt, and get visibility and guardrails over AI traffic.

PAIN POINT 1 25 points

Under the EU AI Act, we are classified as a 'Provider' for our internal AI systems. We need to demonstrate robustness and cybersecurity compliance to satisfy Article 15. How does Cisco help us meet these specific requirements?

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

AI Defense (AI Model and Application Validation). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. Cisco AI Defense is specifically designed to support Provider obligations under the EU AI Act. We utilize algorithmic red teaming technology for AI Model & App Validation, which identifies safety and security vulnerabilities at scale.

Outcome. It automates the technical evidence gathering required for "Conformity Assessments." By mapping AI-specific threats to standardized frameworks (like MITRE ATLAS and OWASP), it provides the documentation and continuous monitoring necessary to prove to regulators that your systems are robust and compliant.

PAIN POINT 2 25 points

We are integrating various open-source models and third-party agents into our internal workflows. How can we ensure these assets aren't introducing vulnerabilities into our environment before they even go live?

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

AI Defense (Supply Chain Risk Management). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. Cisco AI Defense addresses this through proactive Supply Chain Risk Management. We scan your model files, repositories, and MCP servers to identify malicious or unsafe assets.

Outcome. It enables "Shift-Left" security by creating an inventory of all AI models and agents. By identifying vulnerabilities before production, it prevents the introduction of malicious code or poisoned data into your ecosystem.

PAIN POINT 3 25 points

We know AI is showing up across our cloud environments faster than security can track it. We're worried we have models, agents, datasets, and MCP-connected tools running without visibility or consistent controls.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

Cisco AI Defense, AI Cloud Visibility (Ai Cloud Visibility). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. That's exactly the visibility gap Cisco AI Defense is built to solve. With AI Cloud Visibility, Cisco AI Defense continuously discovers AI assets across distributed cloud environments, including models, agents, datasets, MCP servers, and agent-to-tool workflows.
Outcome. identifies rogue or unsanctioned AI assets Maps relationships across data, models, agents, and tools Gives security teams a single-pane-of-glass view of AI exposure Helps close gaps before unknown AI usage becomes a production risk.

PAIN POINT 4 25 points

We're running AI workloads in cloud accounts, but we don't have a reliable way to see which models and AI assets are actually in use. We're also concerned about workloads reaching out to third-party AI models without security knowing about it. And even when we do know the traffic path, we need a practical way to inspect and enforce guardrails on prompt and response traffic in the cloud without changing every application.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

AI Defense = AI visibility and guardrail integration Multicloud Defense = cloud account connection, traffic visibility, policy attachment, and egress enforcement (AI Runtime Protection). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. That's exactly what the AI Defense-Multicloud Defense integration is designed to address. Cisco AI Defense uses the integration to discover AI assets in your cloud environments and identify external AI destinations your workloads are calling.
Outcome. Finds AI assets in cloud accounts Identifies third-party AI model usage Uses existing cloud-network control points for enforcement Avoids relying only on application-level changes.

Cloud Edge

The conversation. Workloads sprawl across AWS, Azure and on-prem, each with its own policy model. Contain lateral movement, prove consistent controls to auditors, and give Cedarline one place to define and enforce policy.

PAIN POINT 1 25 points

If a breach occurs in one of our public cloud instances, we are terrified that the attacker will move laterally into our core on-premises systems. How can we contain these threats in a multicloud environment?

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

Multicloud Defense (Multicloud Defense Gateways). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. Multicloud Defense leverages macro and micro-segmentation capabilities to enforce strict communication boundaries. By integrating with our Hybrid Mesh Firewall and Hypershield, we can isolate workloads and inspect traffic between cloud segments, effectively stopping lateral movement before it reaches your sensitive data.

Outcome. It provides granular visibility and control over east-west traffic. By applying Zero Trust principles across the hybrid fabric, you transform your network into a series of secure, isolated zones that prevent an attacker from pivoting through your infrastructure.

PAIN POINT 2 25 points

Our auditors require proof that our security controls are applied consistently across all our cloud workloads. Gathering this data from different cloud providers is a manual, time-consuming nightmare.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

Multicloud Defense (Multicloud Defense Visibility). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. Cisco Multicloud Defense provides unified logging and traceability. Because our security framework is integrated across the network fabric, you can generate consolidated reports that map directly to your compliance requirements (such as NIS2 or DORA) across all cloud environments from a single dashboard.

Outcome. It automates the collection of evidence for security audits. By consolidating logs and policy enforcement data, you create a "single source of truth" that simplifies compliance reporting and demonstrates proactive governance to regulators.

PAIN POINT 3 25 points

We have workloads spread across AWS, Azure, and on-premises data centers. Managing security policies individually in each cloud environment is creating massive operational overhead and leading to inconsistent security posture.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

Multicloud Defense (Unified Security across public clouds).
Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. Cisco Multicloud Defense, integrated within our Hybrid Mesh Firewall architecture, provides a unified control plane. You can define security policies once via Security Cloud Control and enforce them consistently across your entire distributed environment, regardless of the underlying cloud provider.

Outcome. It replaces siloed, manual configuration with centralized orchestration. By abstracting the security policy from the cloud-native tools, it ensures that your security posture is uniform and eliminates the "configuration drift" that occurs when managing multiple cloud consoles.

PAIN POINT 4 25 points

We have workloads on-prem, in cloud, and in mixed environments, and policy consistency is becoming difficult. Every environment feels different, and we're worried about drift.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

Cisco Secure Workload Cisco Secure Firewall Cisco Secure Firewall Management Center (FMC) Cisco Security Cloud Control (Secure Workload Integration with Secure Firewall Management Center). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. That's a common hybrid environment challenge. Cisco Secure Workload helps create a more unified segmentation model by using application dependency awareness and AI/ML-driven policy discovery to define policy based on how workloads actually communicate.

Outcome. Reduces policy drift across hybrid and multicloud environments Aligns policy to application behavior, not just static IP-based rules Supports consistent macro and micro controls together.

3

CASE STUDY 3 · REFERENCE

DC Edge · Perimeter Firewall

The conversation. A mixed-vendor perimeter, an inherited rulebase and mostly encrypted traffic leave blind spots and a slow response. Restore visibility, speed the response, and modernise detection with the team they have.

PAIN POINT 1 25 points

When our security tools detect a compromised device, our manual response time is too slow. By the time we identify the user and manually isolate the port, the attacker has already moved through the network.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

ISE (Security Group Tags (pxGrid integration)). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. Cisco ISE integrates with your security ecosystem via pxGrid and Adaptive Network Control (ANC). When a threat is detected, ISE can automatically trigger a quarantine policy, isolating the compromised device in real-time without requiring manual intervention.

Outcome. It automates the "Response" phase of the incident lifecycle. By bridging the gap between detection and enforcement, it stops threats at the speed of the network.

PAIN POINT 2 25 points

Our firewall environment has become too complex to manage manually.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

Cisco Security Cloud Control, FMC, FTD (Unified Policy Administration). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. Cisco applies AI-driven analysis to firewall telemetry and policy data to surface optimization opportunities, reduce manual troubleshooting, and guide cleaner policy administration.

Outcome. Reduces manual policy review; identifies redundant/stale rules; lowers risk from human error.

PAIN POINT 3 25 points

Most of our traffic is encrypted, so we've lost visibility into a huge part of our environment.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

Cisco Secure Firewall (FTD), FMC, Security Cloud Control (EVE). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. Encrypted Visibility Engine (EVE) uses AI/ML-based fingerprinting to analyze encrypted traffic patterns and identify suspicious behavior without decrypting the payload.
Outcome. Restores visibility into encrypted blind spots; avoids the performance/privacy overhead of decrypt-everything strategies.

PAIN POINT 4 25 points

We're worried traditional signature-based detection won't catch new or unknown attacks quickly enough.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

Cisco Secure Firewall (FTD), FMC, Security Cloud Control (Snort ML). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. That's exactly where Snort ML helps. It adds machine-learning-based detection inside the Snort 3 engine to identify exploit behavior associated with unknown/zero-day threats.
Outcome. Addresses the gap between known and unknown threat detection; reduces dependence on signature timing.

Macro & Micro Segmentation

The conversation. A flat data centre and fragmented Kubernetes networking invite east-west movement. Build segmentation Cedarline can adopt safely, with runtime visibility and application-dependency awareness so nothing breaks.

PAIN POINT 1 25 points

Network policy helps, but we also need to know what's happening at runtime inside the workload. We need better detection of suspicious behavior and policy violations.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

Isovalent (Tetragon Runtime Security). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. That's where Tetragon comes in. Tetragon extends the value of Cilium by providing eBPF-based runtime security and threat detection.

Outcome. Adds runtime visibility beyond basic network controls
Detects suspicious system and network behavior in real time
Strengthens Kubernetes security with deeper workload-level insight.

PAIN POINT 2 25 points

Our Kubernetes networking feels fragmented across clusters and environments. We're dealing with too many moving parts, inconsistent policies, and too much operational complexity.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

the fitting Cisco solution (Cilium Networking Policies). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. That's exactly where Isovalent Cilium helps. Cilium provides a modern, eBPF-based Kubernetes networking layer that gives you consistent connectivity, policy enforcement, and visibility across clusters and environments.

Outcome. Replaces brittle, IP-centric networking models with a Kubernetes-native approach
Improves consistency across dynamic cluster environments
Reduces operational complexity with a more unified networking and policy layer.

PAIN POINT 3 25 points

Right now we're stitching together separate tools for networking, security, and observability in Kubernetes, and it's creating too much overhead.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

cilium and tetragon. Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. That's exactly the consolidation opportunity Isovalent addresses. With Cilium for networking and policy, and Tetragon for runtime security, you get a more unified platform for connectivity, segmentation, observability, and security.

Outcome. Consolidates multiple functions into one platform approach Reduces tool sprawl and operational friction Improves context sharing between networking, security, and operations teams.

PAIN POINT 4 25 points

We know we need microsegmentation, but we don't have enough visibility into east-west flows or application dependencies to create policy safely. We don't want to break the application.

 **Problem Identifier**
/ 5

Correctly names the pain point and the requirements behind this concern, not just the surface ask.

 **Solution Designer**
/ 10

Cisco Secure Workload Cisco Secure Firewall (Application dependency mapping). Reward the right solution, architecture and approach for Cedarline.

 **Value Communicator**
/ 10

How it works. That's one of the biggest reasons customers adopt Cisco Secure Workload. It gives you deep visibility into workload communication and application dependency mapping, so you can see how applications actually behave before enforcing policy.

Outcome. Reveals actual application communication paths Reduces the risk of segmentation causing outages Enables more precise policy design and staged enforcement.